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Emigration and Internationalism

Cubans had been traveling, and moving, to south Florida well before 1959. Cigar makers and their workers sought refuge from the nineteenth-century independence wars by moving their operations to Tampa; by the 1950s, as Alejandro Portes and Alex Stepick note, “for many middle-class Cubans, a South Florida vacation was a yearly ritual; for the wealthy, it could be a daily excursion.”[1]

Thus for those Cubans who opposed, were excluded, or found themselves increasingly alienated from the Revolution, emigration was often the first resort. Between 1960 and 1962 200,000 Cubans left, most of them for Miami.[2] In the Revolution’s first decade, over half a million Cubans emigrated.[3] By 2004, there were 1.4 million Cubans in the United States, 900,000 of them immigrants and 500,000 born in the United States identifying as Cuban-Americans.[4]

The exodus of such a large portion of the population – 10 percent, by the end of the twentieth century – had complex effects on Cuban society. Most of those who left in the 1960s belonged to the upper classes, and were white. Cuba lost large numbers of doctors, professionals, and businesspeople. This meant, on one hand, that people with the precise skills needed to build a new society were not there to participate. On the other hand, it also contributed to the sense that Cuban society would be rebuilt from the ground up, in completely new ways. The Revolution would train new doctors, professionals, and managers, to reconstruct society in new, revolutionary ways.

In contrast to other revolutionary situations, in which the displaced upper classes stayed in the country and fought to bring back the old order, Cuba’s displaced upper classes were simply absent. They still